process; 50 per cent after three years and another 25 per cent after five years, effectively making it only 25 per cent retention. This was just not practical. Six to eight months would go into basic training and deployment, and the process for the selection of personnel to be released would also take about six months, meaning that any given jawan would be effective for just about two years. There were also practical issues to be considered: Who would do this evaluation and on what basis? For Officers, it was on the basis of their Annual Confidential Reports (ACR), but annual reports are not initiated below the NCO level. What then, would be the objective parameters for testing and who would do the testing? The Commanding Officer of the unit or a centralized Board of Officers? Even if such a board were to be constituted, would it be at the Brigade or Division level, and how would they carry out their task? By assembling all the affected personnel in one place for screening or based on the CO's recommendations? Would the cohort be seen as one or would it be arm and service-wise? If seen as one, then some jawans who had served in field would get released while those in peace stations would be retained, which would be a travesty. In a 3-plus-2 format, the retention process would become one long and never-ending exercise, which would adversely affect other tasks. These deliberations would continue for long. The problem was even more for the Air Force, for whom three years was just not enough to impart the technical skills required to carry out repairs or periodic operating and maintenance tasks on high-value platforms like aircraft, where at least a year and a half was required to impart the necessary technical skills, leaving very little residual service. Ultimately, a middle path was agreed upon, a one-step retention after four years of service.

As per the Army proposal, all the personnel were to be recruited with the same terms and conditions of service,

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation